

# Measuring Sponsorship Performance: Challenge and Direction

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## ABSTRACT

Corporate investment in sponsorship represents one of marketing's more dramatic investment stories of recent decades with global sponsorship expenditure forecast to reach US \$53.3 billion in 2013. The scale of this investment, as well as the scrutiny to which sponsorship activity has been subjected during the "Financial Crisis" has added significant momentum to the demand for improved methodologies for evaluating the returns resulting from sponsorship investment. Indeed a range of recent sponsorship studies clearly indicate the pressure, not just for greater accountability, but a demand for new and improved methodologies for measuring sponsorship performance. Against this backdrop this special issue of *Psychology and Marketing* is timely. It seeks to bring together a selected series of papers from leading edge practitioners and academics which critically review certain current approaches to evaluation, explores important research methodology issues, and outlines recently developed models which quantify the value generated by sponsorship investment. It is hoped that this special issue will lead to increased levels of understanding and interaction between the academic community concerned with researching sponsorship and the practitioner community charged with managing sponsorship and will, in future, serve as a key reference source for these communities in their quest for improved methodologies to measure sponsorship performance. © 2013 Wiley Periodicals, Inc.

## CONTEXT

Until the emergence of digital and social media, sponsorship had been the most rapidly growing method of marketing over several decades. In 1987, global sponsorship spending was estimated at \$5.6 billion and by 2007 it was valued at \$37.9 billion (see Figure 1). Over much of the two decades prior to 2007, sponsorship spending in the US market had exhibited double digit annual growth and in so doing achieved growth rates several multiples higher than that achieved in both advertising and sales promotions. The advent of the financial crisis had, as elsewhere in marketing, significant consequences for sponsorship expenditure with annual growth rates, both globally and in major markets, being significantly curtailed. Year-on-year growth has recovered, with cautiously optimistic forecasts now being made, but the double digit patterns so evident prior to the financial crisis has not as yet returned.

## CONTEXT—THE CHANGING WORLD OF SPONSORSHIP

Sponsorship as an activity is undergoing fundamental change. These changes are now briefly discussed in terms of general industry changes and more fully

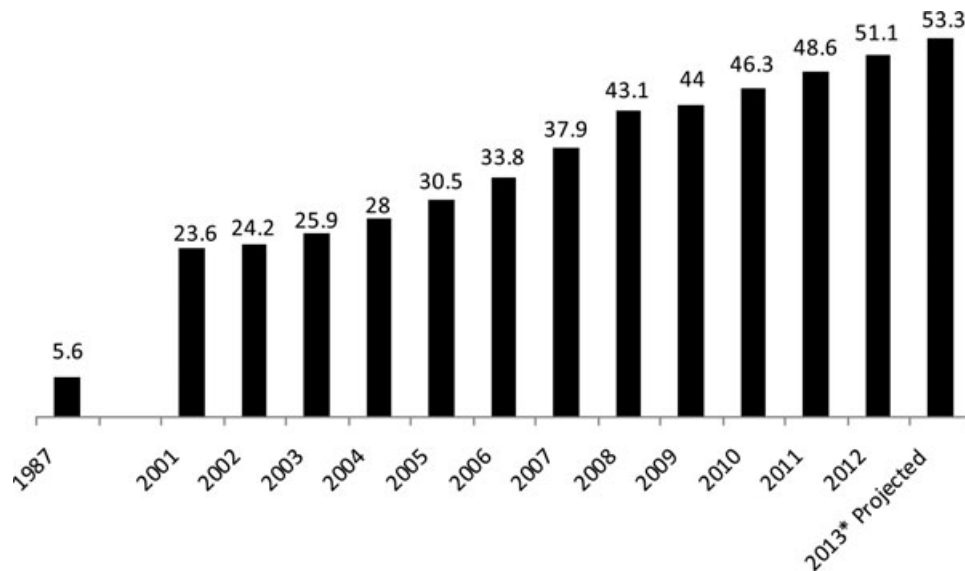
in terms of changes with implications for sponsorship performance measurement. General industry changes include the following.

### Changing Patterns of Expenditure

While sport remains the largest sponsorship category, its dominance is reduced as other investment categories (e.g. broadcast and social media and venue sponsorship) come to greater prominence, even though sport can also represent an inherent component of these newer categories.

### Expanding Range of Sponsors

The profile of active sponsors has changed as internet gaming and gambling brands are increasingly involved. Furthermore, brands from emerging economies, particularly the BRIC countries are increasingly visible on the global sponsorship stage (PWC, 2010). This emergence is reflected in the upcoming major global events in Brazil (FIFA World Cup in 2014 and the IOC Olympic Games in 2016) and Russia (Winter Olympics 2014) and the increased global prominence of cricket from the Indian subcontinent.



**Figure 1.** Global sponsorship rights spending (US\$ in billion) 1987–2013.  
*Source:* IEG Special Report, Chicago (2013).

### An Increasingly Regulated Industry

As an industry, sponsorship is increasingly regulated with sectors such as alcohol, gambling, and those involved in producing high fat, high sugar products facing varying degrees of criticism and threatened regulation in different global economies (Clark & Brownell, 2012; Day et al. 2009, 2011; Kelly et al., 2011ba,b; Moital et al., 2012).

### The Proliferation of Sponsorship Activity

Recent forecasts suggest a modest recovery in global sponsorship expenditure. However, as sponsorship rights holders increasingly “sweat their assets” in pursuit of greater revenue flows, greater numbers of sponsors are being drawn into the sponsorship arena which in turn leads to greater proliferation in the sector (Dundas, 2011; O'Reilly & Madill, 2007).

Changes with particular implications for sponsorship performance measurement include the following.

### Sponsorship and the Image of the Industry

The Global Financial Crisis cast sponsorship into a uncomfortable storm of political, media, and public outrage with hostile attention focusing on sponsorship as a business practice and particularly on instances of Chairman's choice and corporate hospitality as well as considerations of overall value. The portrayal of sponsorship by Senator John Kerry as “wasteful” were echoed in a range of media and political commentary around the globe (Condon, 2009; ESA, 2009a; IEG, 2009; Martin, 2009; McCullagh 2009; Sandison, 2009; SportBusiness, 2009; Toms, 2009; Wall Street Journal,

2009). Related concerns regarding value and credibility in sponsorship were also raised by industry insiders (Future Sport & Entertainment, 2009; Whatling, 2009). As a direct consequence of this damaging portrayal, sponsorship and its value generating capacity and by extension the vexed question of the measurement of sponsorship effectiveness has been pushed to the forefront of discussion both within and outside the industry.

### The Scale of Sponsorship Investment

As indicated in Figure 1, global sponsorship spending in 2013 is expected to reach \$53.3 billion. This overall estimate perhaps masks the scale of sponsorship activity by individual companies and indeed the importance of sponsorship to individual rights holders. According to International Events Group (IEG), the top 10 US sponsors in 2011 spent between \$135 million and \$345 million, with the top sponsor, Pepsi Co estimated to have spent between \$340 million and \$345 million (IEG, 2012a). The scale of sponsorship spending around major events is also significant. Separate from the sponsorship of National Olympic Committees, individual competing teams (USA Track and Field) and indeed individual athletes (Usain Bolt), the London Olympics involved four different levels of sponsorship association; there were 11 TOP sponsors (each paying \$100 million), seven London 2012 Olympic Partners (each paying \$63 million); seven London 2012 Olympic Supporters (each paying \$31 million); and 28 London 2012 Providers and suppliers (each paying \$15 million). Collectively these sponsors paid \$2178 million in fees for association with the London Olympics (Guardian, 2012). The cost of activation was additional to this

initial rights fee expenditure. Expenditure on this scale demands the rigorous evaluation of its effectiveness.

### **Demand for Greater Sponsorship Accountability**

Perhaps the greatest challenge facing sponsorship is that of providing greater transparency and accountability. As investment in sponsorship has grown and against the backdrop of recent criticism of sponsorship, there are understandable demands for a greater focus on sponsorship evaluation. The European Sponsorship Association/Sports Marketing Surveys (ESA/SMS) study in 2007 (ESA, 2007) reported that 57% of sponsors believed that the importance of researching return on investment (ROI) would increase (on this issue the figure for Northern Europe was 72% as against 42% for the rest of Europe). This study took place as the “financial crisis” broke and subsequent indicators would suggest that the demand for greater accountability in sponsorship has in fact increased since its publication. According to the 2010 ANA/IEG research (PR Web, 2010), nearly 80% of respondents reported that the need for validated results for their sponsorship has increased in the past two years as a result of having to justify expenditures to senior personnel.

A recent PWC Report (2010) suggests that “as sponsors allocate increasing amounts of money to sport, there will be intensifying pressure for far more sophisticated measurement techniques to demonstrate the returns on that investment” (p. 5). Similarly a 2012 IFM Sports Marketing Survey Report (January 2012) suggests that 60% of respondents believed that “the importance of research return on investment is likely to increase within their organization.” Moving from the global to one particular market, a 2011 sponsorship manager’s survey by Incorporated Society of British Advertisers (ISBA) found that evaluation was the biggest challenge facing their members (ISBA, 2011). In fact, the two topics shown as most relevant to members were “calculating return on investment” and “evaluation of effectiveness.” According to the 2012 IEG/Performance Research Survey, 86% of respondents agreed that the “need for validated results from sponsorship increasing in the past one to two years.”

### **From “Badging” to “Engagement”**

Over time, sponsor ambitions have evolved from primarily seeking brand exposure and driving brand awareness and association to a position where sophisticated sponsors increasingly employ sponsorship, either as a platform for the provision of experiential marketing opportunities or as a conduit to engaging with consumer passions, in order to drive brand engagement (Close et al., 2006, Octagon, 2009, ARF, 2008, Pettit et al., 2008). Inevitably this redirection has implications for where sponsors seek to focus their evaluation and in terms of the metrics that are applicable. In this

regard it is interesting to note that a key finding of the 2012 Decision Makers survey is that “sponsors survey sees less reliance on ads, signage . . . While they embrace ways to engage better, sponsors still come up short on measurement” (Performance Research, 2012).

### **Sponsorship and the Digital World**

As elsewhere in business and in society at large, the advent of digital has significant implications for sponsorship. New media provide focused channels of communications to achieve traditional sponsorship objectives, such as building brand awareness and developing associations. In addition to this capacity, the very nature of social media as connection platforms render them particularly valuable for consumer interaction and engagement, both for marketing generally (IAB/Carat, 2006; IAB, 2011) and in particular in relation to sponsorship (Cahill and Meenaghan, 2013). Given its particular capabilities, the redirection of marketing budgets is inevitable. Indeed one notable sponsor, Nike, was reported to have spent \$771 million on “unmeasured” media (direct marketing, internet, paid search social media) compared to a spend of \$113 million on traditional media (Cendrowski, 2012). The scale of the reorientation of sponsorship toward social media is emphasized by the fact that the most recent major global sports event, the London Olympics, has been labeled the *Socialympics*

### **A Strategic and Broadened View of Sponsorship**

Traditional sponsorship has been represented as a largely marketing and often as a marketing communications option with which to address large-scale consumer audiences, with other stakeholder groups often regarded as useful additional add-on targets. Today many sponsors view sponsorship in a more strategic and holistic way, regarding it more strategically, as a versatile platform for communication and engagement with multiple stakeholder groups, each of whom is individually valued and addressed in a focused way within the totality of the sponsorship program.

This perspective requires that sponsorship programs as multifaceted opportunities be considered and selected in terms of their ability to fulfill a range of predetermined roles with strategically important stakeholder groups. Each usage of the sponsorship platform requires the specification of objectives, the determination of budgets, the creation of activation programs, and ultimately a program for evaluating the effects achieved with each particular target stakeholder group. The mass consumer market continues to represent the major focus for sponsor involvement, yet sponsorship enables the realization of strategic roles with a range of stakeholder groups, including company own staff, trade associates in terms of suppliers and distributors, shareholders, as well as media and in certain instances

regulators. As sponsors and rights holders are enjoined in a mutually beneficial symbiotic relationship, the property rights holder must also be considered a major stakeholder in the sponsor's set of managed relationships.

Given the nature of many of the effects sought with these various stakeholder groups, it is obvious that a purely ROI perspective is not appropriate in all instances and that the broader return on objectives (ROO) approach must also be applied (ESA, 2009b). However, irrespective of the performance measurement approach applied, the conventional management process of determination of role and objectives, budgets, and activation programs for each stakeholder group must apply, with related program ambitions and expected Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) specified at the outset. In effect no less rigor must apply because other stakeholder groups are involved or because the nature of the effects sought do not readily lend themselves to a purely ROI-based measurement approach.

## PERFORMANCE MEASUREMENT IN SPONSORSHIP—CURRENT PRAXIS

Research suggests that there is a “measurement deficit” in sponsorship (ANA/IEG, 2010; ESA, 2007; IEG/Performance Research, 2012). While large-scale sponsors both fund and undertake more extensive and sophisticated research, the evidence from the industry overall is that the extent, nature, and quality of effectiveness measurement is limited. Research budgets for performance evaluation are frequently inadequate or nonexistent and sponsorship decision makers are cognizant of their lack of adequate performance measurement while equally aware of increased demands for greater accountability (Meenaghan, 2011). Yet, despite this evident measurement, one senses that there is an almost universal willingness to assume and proclaim success with regard to corporate sponsorship involvement. Against such a backdrop, it is difficult to disagree with the observation (from Bronn, Olson, & Thjomoe, 2002) that there is

a seeming paradox of satisfaction with sponsorship results without quantitative or qualitative measures of what these results are.

The existence of a measurement deficit raises fundamental questions about the strategic management of sponsorship. In particular, how is it possible to undertake the effective management of this corporate investment without reference to proper performance results? In the absence of these results, one must surmise that much decision making in sponsorship is reliant on limited, perhaps flawed information, personal judgment, and “educated guesswork.”

## IS SPONSORSHIP DIFFERENT?

Against the backdrop of evidence regarding measurement practice in sponsorship, it is perhaps worthwhile to briefly examine the contention that sponsorship is different and thus the attendant suggestion that it is somehow less amenable to performance measurement. This contention is explicit in the following quotations, the dates of which are noteworthy.

Marketing has become so organised and pseudo-scientific that it is only relatively uncharted areas like sponsorship that hunch and flair still thrive. And it is probably best to treat sponsorship as an extension of public relations activity . . . and good PR men quite rightly resist the slide rule of the marketing researcher on the grounds that such activity cannot be scientifically evaluated. Sponsorship should be viewed in much the same light.

(Mintel, 1980)

The sponsorship industry has advanced a great deal since the time the phrase “sponsorship can't be measured” typically went unchallenged. As all aspects of the industry have grown more sophisticated, and as the dollar value and prominence of partnerships has grown substantially, the need for accountability has become vitally important.

Sponsorship ROI, IEG (2012b)

While recognizing that all elements of marketing and marketing communications possess different features and capabilities, sponsorship is most often contrasted with media advertising in general (Hastings, 1984; Hoek et al., 1997; McDonald, 1991; Meenaghan 2001) and indeed with specific aspects of advertising (Olson & Thjomoe, 2009, 2012; Walliser, 1997). The comparison of sponsorship and traditional advertising has been previously addressed in terms of a range of discernible differences which included the mutuality of benefit, the consumer interaction process, the comparative nature of the communications process, as well as sponsorship's location at the “leisure end of marketing.” While sponsorship may be different in certain respects, such differences are no impediment to the task of performance measurement and, thus, the “sponsorship is different” argument is largely irrelevant to the need for or ability to undertake proper performance analysis (Meenaghan, 2005). It could be argued that the broadened usage of sponsorship to address multiple stakeholders renders performance measurement more complex, but no less amenable to effectiveness evaluation if alternative research approaches, that is, ROO are rigorously adopted. Similarly the fact that sponsorship is woven through events and activities with which consumers have passionate relationships indicates a different feature and indeed a comparative competence of sponsorship, but of itself does not preclude evaluation, but merely highlights a particular focus for evaluation.



## CONTENTS OF THIS SPECIAL ISSUE

As stated, the purpose of this Special Issue is to examine the topic of performance measurement in sponsorship. While many areas of possible focus within the confines of this topic are addressed, a fundamental rationale of this special issue was to bring together the perspectives of both academics and practitioners in this field. Each of the individual papers included in this special issue is briefly introduced.

Recent years have seen a significant concentration by academics on the topic of sponsorship awareness and its measurement. Within this concentration, various factors which affect respondent association of sponsor and event have been examined, including sponsor prominence, sponsor relatedness, as well as aspects of question wording and sequencing, all of which are central to the measurement of sponsorship recall and recognition. The paper by Cornwell and Humphreys explores memory for sponsorship relationships. It outlines the progress to date in the understanding of memory and sponsorship relationships and points out current shortcomings in understanding of these relationships. In particular it seeks to move toward a more complete explanation of sponsorship effects.

Research evidence from practice suggests a significant deficit with regard to measurement. However, even where evaluation is undertaken there is concern about the credibility of the research methodologies and aspects of those methodologies which are sometimes employed. Credibility of such methodologies and metrics is the theme of the paper by Meenaghan and O'Sullivan which focuses on the two main metrics currently employed by the industry, "Media Exposure" and "Sponsorship Awareness." It outlines the latitude provided by these metrics and the variability of outcomes that can be extracted from their use or in some cases potential abuse. Such latitude in conceptualization and application can extend to having the same sponsorship program receive quite radically different evaluations in terms of success/failure based on the same raw data. This raises serious questions about the credibility and effectiveness of current sponsorship measurement. The authors further suggests that in order to secure the future of sponsorship and exploit its competitive media advantage, there is a need for the industry to reposition itself in terms of brand experience, engagement, and involvement rather than mere exposure.

The paper by Kourovskaia and Meenaghan outlines an approach to assessing the financial impact of sponsorship investment. Based on a number of interrelated proprietary models, the Millward Brown Optimor (MBO) model enables the specific brand financial uplift created by a sponsorship program and the consequent shareholder value to be identified and calculated. The process is based on a comprehensive segmentation of the business and the modeling of financial performance therein as well as determining the

role of brand in driving usage choice. Brand contribution is identified and forecasted (in financial terms using a brand discount rate) and the precise impact of the sponsorship is identified and calculated based on a comparison of market segments delineated as sponsorship exposed versus nonsponsorship exposed.

The paper, Sponsorship at O2—"The Belief that Repaid" by Cahill and Meenaghan outlines a specific case study focusing on the O2 brand in the Irish marketplace and the strategically chosen role for sponsorship in its armory of marketing options. It details the key strategic pillars which underpin the approach to sponsorship as a set of beliefs that hold sponsorship policy and activation together. In order to ensure that brand was the basis for differentiation, the company chooses a marketing mix weighted toward sponsorship and placed "participation" at the core of activation. The strategic choices regarding the balance of resources between paid-for media and sponsorship, and in the latter case between assets and activation are explored. The paper explains how the choice and activation of sponsorships sought to develop participative interaction with customers to promote emotionally driven loyalty. Two case studies relating to sport and entertainment sponsorship are detailed with particular reference to innovative and creative activation through social networks.

The paper focuses on the various points at which measurement is brought to bear and the range of metrics—including quantitative tracking measures and softer measures, such as sentiment analysis and social media conversations—utilized in this evaluation process. It outlines a comprehensive approach to measuring sponsorship effectiveness and demonstrates how results are translatable to monetary values. This particular case study has been the recipient of several major international awards. It was the winner of the European Sponsorship Association Awards (B2C category) in 2011 as well as receiving a Cyber Lion award at the Cannes Lions International Advertising Festival among others.

New Challenges in Measuring Sponsorship Performance by Meenaghan et al. seeks to address a number of changes taking place in sponsorship which have implications for performance measurement. One such challenge is the extent to which major sponsors now view sponsorship more holistically and strategically as a platform to address a broad range of stakeholder groups enabled by sponsorship. The emergence of new media has implications for sponsorship at two levels, first, in terms of the sponsorship of particular social media channels, for example, sponsored blogs. Second and perhaps more important, is the increased utilization of social media as sponsorship activation channels. Both of these changes represent importance challenges for the evaluation of sponsorship effects. These challenges are considered against the backdrop of key principles regarding evaluation and the current state of industry practice with regard to sponsorship evaluation.

## CHALLENGE AND DIRECTION

Sponsorship as an activity and as an industry involving sponsors, rights holders, and related service agencies faces a future of both optimism and challenge. On the optimistic front the industry is again experiencing growth on a global basis and can expect to thrive as global economic conditions improve. Sponsorship which enables access to consumer passions (e.g., sports, arts) and concerns (e.g., causes) is particularly well placed to provide the engagement and experiential platforms increasingly sought by brands with the additional assistance of a developing range of social media to provide the pathways to consumers that sponsors seek. Against the backdrop of this optimism is the increased threat of regulation for certain sectors and of particular relevance to this Special Issue are concerns expressed both within and outside the industry regarding issues of sponsorship effectiveness, value, credibility, and validity, all of which are bound up with sponsorship performance. As sponsorship performance measurement is the focus of this special issue, a number of pertinent challenges and directions are highlighted.

### Demand for Greater Accountability

The increasing pressure for greater accountability in sponsorship is a major theme in a number of reports cited in this introduction. This pressure is driven by factors, such as the increased scale of sponsorship investment, the requirement for greater accountability in marketing generally, and the demands for proper corporate governance and transparency in business at large. Additionally, the strictures and expectations placed on business sectors receiving government bail-out funding (financial, automobile, etc.) in certain markets as well the industry's own awareness of and response to the criticism leveled against sponsorship represent additional pressure. Collectively such factors serve to increase the demand for greater accountability in sponsorship and represent a significant challenge for the industry.

### The Credibility of Research Evidence in Sponsorship Measurement

The credibility of research evidence in sponsorship can on occasion cause concern and a charge sometimes leveled at sponsorship is that the results of the measurement process serve to validate decisions taken rather than serve to measure the effectiveness of the investment decision itself. This evaluation/validation concern is evident in the following quotation

It's not about eyeballs. Most sponsorship evaluations are exercises in validation . . . . Obviously, it's the client's choice if they want to use such data to val-

idate their marketing investment. But the price for keeping evaluation such a comfortable exercise can only be a loss of integrity and credibility, a failure to learn and a waste of investment. Media value is just the worst offender in the battery of validation techniques.

(Whatling, 2009)

Another interesting insight into the practice of evaluation is provided by *Sponsorship Works*, a collection of 23 case studies in *Sponsorship Works* (2007). Of the 23 cases included, 20 contained no data tables to validate marketing effectiveness and only three had any accompanying data tables or figures. Overall the "proof" of successful sponsorship was heavily reliant on exposure data, for example, "In 2005, 279 million media impressions were generated through more than 400 broadcast segments and 900 print articles" (*Sponsorship Works*, 2007 p. 58). Proof of success was particularly reliant on qualitative comment from those charged with sponsorship management. Interestingly and tellingly, this volume contains 55 color plates across the 23 case studies showing instances of sponsor signage and activation for the various cases; a clear demonstration that exposure and publicity remains the paramount indicators of success for many players. Reliance on such metrics as the basis for "sponsorship working" must be emphatically regarded as inadequate.

### The Requirement for Proof of Effectiveness

Sponsorship has been portrayed as wasteful, ineffective, and guilty of employing outdated practices and evaluation methodologies, and the credibility of sponsorship research has been called into question. In countering such allegations, the industry often cites individual case instances, such as VISA or Coca Cola and the Olympics, Heineken and the ERC (European Rugby Cup), or Red Bull and Formula One. Such defenses are sometimes supported by selected data from effective campaigns; quite often they are not. The case for sponsorship suffers from the lack of a comprehensive, credible, and accessible body of evidence which industry spokespersons can confidently and convincingly point to. When faced with a similar situation, the advertising industry took steps to provide the necessary proof in support of the contention that advertising works. In 1968, the American Marketing Association established the Effie Awards and in 1980 the UK Institute of Practitioners in Advertising (IPA) commenced its advertising effectiveness awards with the clear rationale of "proving" that "advertising works" through making available a body of case study evidence to that effect. Today this IPA databank, as a "body of evidence," contains some 1400 cases, indicating advertising effectiveness and additionally in excess of 550 case studies have been published in the IPA Advertising Works series (IPA, 2013). Similar evidence in support

of advertising has been compiled elsewhere. Today, the role and effectiveness of advertising as a necessary corporate investment is rarely the subject of political, media, or business debate. It is widely accepted that “advertising works,” a contention with which consumers in their behavior and perceptions seem not to overly disagree. The lessons for sponsorship are clear.

Overall, it would be reasonable to suggest that there is a published “proof deficit” in relation to sponsorship in comparison with advertising with which it often competes for resources. While acknowledging that sponsorship attracts a significantly lesser percentage of the overall marketing budget than advertising and is in fact less well developed as a business activity when compared to advertising, the obvious challenge now is to assemble an irrefutable and published evidence-based case in support of the proposition that sponsorship works.

### **Sponsorship Engagement and Involvement—The Measurement Challenge**

A unique competence of sponsorship is its capacity to engage with consumers (as well as other stakeholders) in their lifestyle setting, while facilitating bonding experiences through involvement with their passions. For this reason many well-known brands employ sponsorship to connect with their brand communities. This strategic refocusing of sponsorship has obvious implications for sponsorship evaluation in terms of the development and application of metrics designed to capture the nature and effects of these bonding experiences.

The comments of Kevin Roberts, Worldwide CEO of Saatchi & Saatchi are apposite.

The ROI that sponsorship has to bother itself with has changed. Return on involvement is where the game is going to be played and sponsorship will get obliterated if it measures itself as it does now on awareness and eyeballs, because those are the wrong, wrong measures in today’s age. We’ve moved from the Attention Economy into an Attraction Economy.

(Roberts, 2009 p. 2)

### **Sponsorship and Social Media**

Major events such as the Superbowl, the European Football Championship, and the Olympic Games all provide showcases for the adoption and use by both sponsors and rights holders, but adoption of social media in sponsorship varies in terms of extent and speed of adoption. Despite this variation, the sheer scale of its usage in sponsorship inevitably means that it is now a significant focus for performance measurement.

Effectiveness measurement in social media by sponsors largely reflects that found in social media evaluation generally and usually involves “buzz” monitoring, sentiment analysis, and engagement. Monitoring which implies a listening element is useful. Buzz analysis can indicate the scale of “noise” (mentions) and dimensions of this, such as location, individual social media, as well as inter-event comparison among others. Sentiment delves deeper into the “buzz” in order to examine the positivity or otherwise of comment which can enable rapid reaction to sponsor behavior as necessary. Engagement, which as a key brand ambition is variously signaled in terms of “likes,” “fans,” “content engagement,” “pass on rates,” etc. However, the ability to easily generate positive results on these latter metrics as well as the favorable and indeed exaggerated interpretation of such metrics as indicators of successful brand engagement must cause some concern.

### **A Sponsorship Effectiveness Dashboard**

The application and suitability of the “dashboard” concept to marketing has been an obvious consequence of marketing’s focus on performance management and accountability. When used in marketing, the dashboard is a readily available display of on-going performance on key marketing indicators (metrics and data), usually drawn from marketing KPIs. Thus, a marketing dashboard can be applied at all stages of the consumer brand interaction (awareness through to loyalty) and involve both input and output measures and focus on both efficiency and effectiveness measures of performance.

Sponsorship can achieve a diverse range of objectives with multiple corporate stake-holders groups and any consideration of a sponsorship measurement dashboard must include a broad range of metrics to indicate the efficiency and effectiveness of sponsorship investment. The concept of a dashboard, while now widely applicable in marketing practice in varying degrees of sophistication, has not as yet received similar application in the field of sponsorship, although some recent proposals regarding the concept of a sponsorship dashboard have recently emerged (Cazalais, 2009; Sponso-rium, 2013).

Sponsor attitudes with regard to evaluation will need to be reconsidered. The oft suggested myth that sponsorship is different and thus less amenable to measurement needs to be dispelled. The versatility of sponsorship may render the measurement process more challenging, but it does not prohibit measurement. Accepting Einstein’s dictum that “not everything that can be counted counts, and not everything that counts can be counted, sponsors need to establish a rigorous and credible measurement system which reflects the strategic rationale underpinning their involvement.



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